

Lesson 2: Responsibility = Accountability = Ownership

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Responsibility, accountability, ownership. These words are interchangeable, right? Not so fast. What if we told you that these three words were a progression that can help you and your team get to the next level?

Imagine this. Two customers walk into a busy lobby. There are two frazzled employees working the front desk, one answering the phones, the other trying to help another customer with some paperwork. As soon as one call ends, the employee picks up the phone again to make a follow-up call. The employee helping the previous customer never looks up from the computer. They call an employee out of the back to answer a question. Neither looks up or acknowledges the growing line of two to three people in front of them. When the question is answered, the third employee immediately retreats to the back office. After all, he doesn't work in the lobby. The employee on the phone turns her back to make it clear that she can't take customers in her line right now. The employee handling the customer is growing more and more stressed, cutting the customer off as they try to ask what he sees as unnecessary questions. Two additional employees walk in the door for their shift, oblivious to the growing line, laughing and joking as they head for the break room. Meanwhile, the line grows.

Then the owner of the business walks in. Seeing the growing line of customers, he immediately springs into action, paging two additional employees. He then asks customers with one set of needs to take the right line, while customers with another set of needs to take the left line, smiling and making eye contact with each customer. He quickly processes some of the small requests first while asking the others to step aside for more detailed service.

When he asked the team members about it later, he gets blank stares.

- “I had to make some phone calls,” the first employee says.
- “I was going as fast as I could,” the second employee says.
- The third employee stares at him blankly. “I don't work the front desk.”
- The fourth and fifth employees? “We were just getting back from lunch. We weren't even on the clock yet, they protest.”

What happened here? A breakdown in teamwork. Yes, customer service, maybe. But Pat would say the growing pileup in this circumstance is around the concept of responsibility

versus accountability versus ownership. Everyone might have been responsible for their task at hand, but not the overall goal of getting customers in and out with great service.

My freshman year, Pat called me into her office and she said, “Nikki, I know you're used to winning a lot of awards, but on this level, you probably won't win those same awards.” And she told me that she needed me to be the defensive stopper. So that became my responsibility. The game would start, and Pat would put me in the game and say, stop the other team's best player. And that was my responsibility. After the game, Pat would tell me if I did a good job or if I didn't do such a good job. And sometimes she would actually have the other player's statistics to show me how many points I allowed. That was to ensure that I would not only be accountable, but that I would take ownership for my performance. And the next game, I would do my best to improve.

So how do you exhibit or encourage ownership among your own work team? Let's take a look.